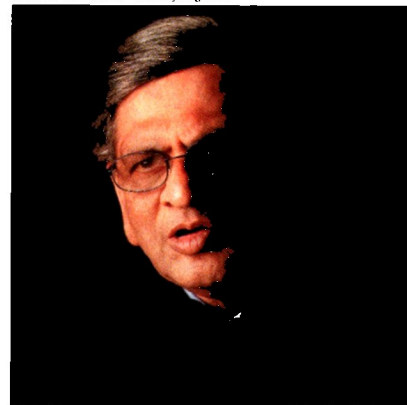


impressed the US and its NATO allies.

There was also a perception among Western powers that India was jeopardising regional stability and negating efforts to bring peace to Afghanistan by not engaging with Pakistan, and that Afghanistan had become the newest ground for Indo-Pak rivalry. Also, India's stand that Pakistan was not doing enough to curb terrorism against it didn't seem to carry as much conviction with the West as it did soon after 26/11. The Pakistan Army had in fact taken on the Taliban in parts of Waziristan and co-operated with the US to take out key militant leaders like

Baitullah Mehsud. The Pakistan Government had also admitted that the 26/11 conspiracy was hatched partly in Pakistan and arrested five of the key suspects of the Lashkar-e-Toiba. India got the impression that hardline diplomacy with Pakistan was yielding diminishing returns with the West unwilling to put the kind of pressure it did on Islamabad as before. With the US willing to negotiate with the Taliban, India's stand on not talking to Pakistan began to look obdurate. As

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“ We have been telling others that any outstanding issues must be addressed through dialogue. How can we prescribe a different medicine for ourselves? ”

S. M. KRISHNA, *Indian External Affairs Minister*

THE TAJ DURING
THE 26/11 ATTACK

AP PHOTO



“ They threatened to attack us after 26/11 and now India has come to us for talks. We never kneeled and did not bow to their pressure. ”

SHAH MAHMOOD QURESHI, *Pakistan Foreign Minister*



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Krishna told INDIA TODAY, “We have been advising others including those involved in Palestine that outstanding issues must be addressed through dialogue. How can we prescribe a different medicine for ourselves?”

Part of the process was triggered by the IPL team-owners not picking up Pakistani cricket players. That led the Pakistan Government to cancel the visit of its chief election commissioner and India found itself on the defensive. By not talking to Pakistan, the civilian society that backed peace with India had

begun to weaken and the hardline militant approach was gaining. Kayani too had ensured that the army regained its grip over Pakistan, and India needed to engage with the civilian government to bolster its credibility. Also, with the Indian economy doing well, Kashmir more settled than before and Home Minister P. Chidambaram revamping India's counter-terror network, there was a greater deal of confidence on Manmohan's part to resume the dialogue process that had been proposed at Sharm el-Sheikh. Apart from deflecting growing international criticism, India would also get a first hand assessment of Pakistan's internal power dynamics by engaging with it.

Now that the Government has gone ahead with the dialogue, it has to be careful not to just let the pressure on Pakistan slip away. There is fear though that India may dilute its core interest in ensuring that Pakistan dismantle its terror network. India must ensure that dialogue with Pakistan does not become a usual structured exercise of the composite dialogue process that Islamabad has been pressing for. But it should be used to bring to the fore India's concerns on terrorism emanating from Pakistan and in assessing the progress on the 26/11 investigations. Besides, a clear message should be sent out that this is certainly not a sign of weakness or business as usual but a step by step approach by India to restore its ties with Pakistan. ■